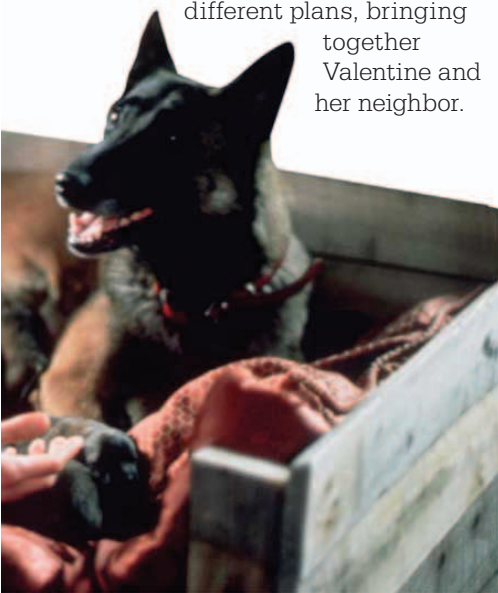


What else to watch: *Ashes and Diamonds* (1958, pp. 146–47) ■ *We Have to Kill This Love* (1972) ■ *Europa, Europa* (1990) ■ *The Double Life of Veronique* (1991)



from his windows and eavesdrops on his neighbors' telephone conversations. It eventually transpires that one of those on whom he eavesdrops is a young judge, Auguste—Valentine's neighbor whom she's never met. In an uncanny echo of Kern's own past, Auguste is being betrayed by his weather-girl partner Karin.

Kern convinces Valentine to try to mend her relationship with her boyfriend in England. She takes his advice, but fate has different plans, bringing together Valentine and her neighbor.



Kern (Jean-Louis Trintignant) reevaluates his life after meeting Valentine. But before he can give her the advice he thinks she needs, he must first do the right thing himself.

Underpinning the movie is a concern with the fraternity of human souls across time and gender. Those bonds can easily be lost to false connections—like the phone lines that seem to link Valentine and her lover and that Kern eavesdrops on, and like the windows through which the judge spies, which give the illusion of contact but make real connection impossible. Only once the glass is shattered can a real bond, a real physical connection between people, be restored.

Yet the two main characters manage to relate to one another in a way that enriches the lives of both of them, and this clear truth adds a warm feeling to the movie's enigmatic ending. There is no obvious sense or clear message to be absorbed as the closing credits roll by, merely an impressionistic reflection on the lives we have been eavesdropping on for a brief time. ■



Krzysztof Kieslowski
Director

Polish director Krzysztof Kieslowski is renowned for his moving meditations on the human spirit. He was born in Warsaw in 1941. His father suffered from TB, so his childhood was nomadic, as the family moved around sanatoriums. At 16 he tried training as a fireman, then as a theater technician, before finally enrolling at the Łódź film school. He made documentaries in the 1960s which were skilled in getting across subversive messages that the authorities would miss. His first major hit movie, *The Double Life of Veronique*, explored human emotion through the lives of two identical women, one Polish and the other French. He then followed with his lauded *Three Colors* trilogy before surprisingly announcing his retirement. He died suddenly in 1996, at just 54.

Key movies

1988 *A Short Film about Killing*
1989 *Decalogue*
1991 *The Double Life of Veronique*
1994 *Three Colors: Red*